The British cavalry – despised by Wellington as undisciplined poseurs "galloping at everything" – for once distinguished themselves by their valour and aggression. The French army suffered a near-rout, with around 7,000 casualties and as many soldiers again taken prisoner.

WATERLOO

For all their draining effect upon French resources and manpower, however, the campaigns of the Peninsular War were never more than a side show. It was in taking on Napoleon at Waterloo in 1815 that the mettle of the Redcoats was tested to the limit, providing them with their finest hour. The effect of the famed Napoleonic artillery was limited as Wellington's men made use of the cover provided by the reverse slope of a hill and lay down whenever possible. The British and their Dutch allies repulsed an onslaught by massed French infantry columns with the grapeshot and canister fired by their field artillery and the musketballs of infantry formed up in line. As Wellington once commented: "I do not desire better sport than to meet one of their columns en masse with our line." When the French cavalry charged, the British infantry formed squares and held firm, the horsemen surging around them like "a heavy surf breaking on a coast". The arrival of the Prussian army in support of the British settled the outcome of the day's fighting, in the course of which Wellington's army had suffered 15,000 casualties.

At the start of the Napoleonic Wars, the British infantry were at least a match for the French, but by the end of the conflict in 1815 they had become tough, battle-hardened fighters, capable of standing up to anything the enemy could throw at them. Wellington's "scum of the earth" could claim to be the men who won the war.

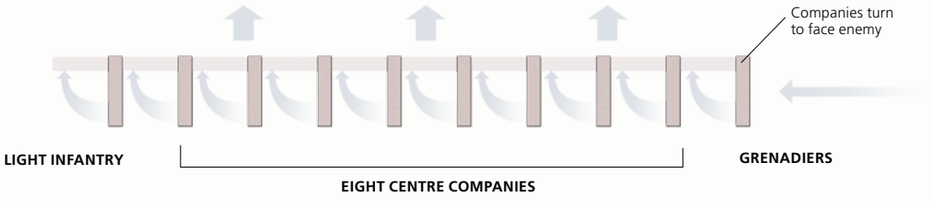
REDCOAT BATTLE TACTICS

All infantrymen in the Napoleonic period were taught to execute battlefield manoeuvres such as deployment from column (the ideal formation for coordinated movement) and into line (the best formation for firing musket volleys). The power of the French artillery, firing solid shot, shells, and canister, forced the infantry to use concealment when possible. Wellington liked to keep his men out of sight of the guns on the reverse slope of a hill until ready to confront the enemy. If no cover was available, soldiers might be ordered to lie down, although they had to stand to deliver their volleys.

The British infantry line was drawn up two ranks deep. Riflemen, acting as skirmishers, would deploy in loose order between the line infantry and the enemy. Officers and NCOs busied themselves around the line. With one rank firing while the other reloaded, infantry could deliver around six volleys a minute – an impressive volume of fire for an enemy to march into. If attacked by cavalry they formed a square with bristling bayonets. This made them more or less impregnable unless cannon fire broke up the square, letting the cavalry in.

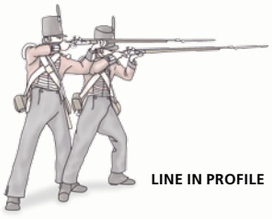
Battalion in column

A battalion was composed of ten companies, each comprising around 50 soldiers. It deployed onto the battlefield in column, then wheeled into line to face the enemy. The two flanking companies (light infantry and grenadiers) were often detached for skirmishing.



Companies in line

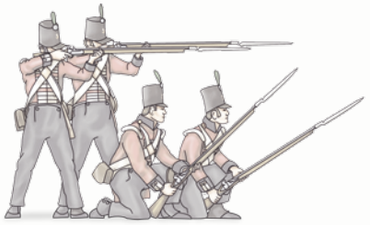
Arranged two-deep, soldiers in line fired in volleys, each loading up to three times a minute. This presented some 1,500 rounds per minute, per battalion, to the enemy, a barrage that destroyed French columns. The volleys were followed by a bayonet charge.


LINE IN PROFILE


SINGLE COMPANY IN LINE FORMATION

Companies in square

Descended from the pike formations that ended the dominance of cavalry on the late-Medieval battlefield, the infantry square formed a four-deep wall, bayonets pointing outwards to provide protection from all directions. The front ranks held position; the rear ranks fired in volleys.


SQUARE IN PROFILE

COMPANY IN SQUARE FORMATION

